AUTONOMY LEVEL 5

Most level 4 autonomy claims are level 2 with logging.

and the gap is in the proving, not the doing

THE STAKES

Someone is going to ask you to prove it.

A customer, an auditor, a regulator, or your own incident review. The question will not be whether it worked. It will be what it was permitted to do, and how you know it stayed inside that.

WHAT EVERYONE ASSUMES

Autonomy is a capability question.

Can the system do the task without a human. That is the demo, and it is the question everyone prepares for.

THE BREAK

It is a provability question.

Can you state what it is allowed to do, and demonstrate it stayed inside that — to someone who does not trust you. That needs different evidence, and it is usually not collected.

THE LADDER

Every rung above the one you can prove is decoration.

L5 · acts, unattended

L4 · acts, audited after

L3 · acts, gated

L2 · acts, reversibly

L1 · suggests

dashed is not modesty. it is the honest rendering of an unreached rung.

Cheap to prove, because little happened.

L1 suggests: a human does everything. L2 acts reversibly: everything can be undone, and the proof is the undo path — plus evidence the undo was actually tested.

L3

A human approves the irreversible ones.

The proof is that the gate cannot be bypassed. Including by the system’s own retry logic, which is where this usually fails and nobody notices.

L4

No human
in the loop.

The proof is a record complete enough that an auditor can reconstruct any single decision after the fact. Most L4 claims have logs. A log is not a reconstruction.

this is where claims outrun evidence

Proof is naming what you have not covered.

Unattended operation is not the absence of failure modes. It is having enumerated them, and being able to say which ones you accept.

THE TEST

Which rung would survive an external audit?

Not which one you operate at. Which one you could defend to somebody who assumes you are wrong.

the honest answer is usually one rung lower